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SECTOR INVESTMENT REPORT · ETHIOPIA

Financial services

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Ethiopia's 32 banks held deposits of ETB 3.5 trillion at end-June 2025 and earned a return on equity of 27.4 percent, while microfinance institutions posted a 27.5 percent return on equity. The 2025 Banking Business Proclamation opens banking to foreign investors through subsidiaries, branches or stakes in domestic banks, and the Ethiopian Securities Exchange has listed seven companies since January 2025. Insurance penetration is only 0.3 percent, and 135.9 million mobile money accounts point to a fast-growing digital payments market.

Key indicators

Indicator	Value	Period
Number of banks	**32 banks, of which 31 are commercial banks**[1]	End-June 2025
Banking sector size	**Commercial bank assets over ETB 4.7 trillion; deposits ETB 3.5 trillion (up 40.7 percent); loans and bonds ETB 3 trillion (up 38.6 percent)**[1]	End-June 2025
Bank soundness	**Capital adequacy ratio 19.1 percent; NPL ratio 3.1 percent (regulatory maximum 5 percent)**[1]	End-June 2025
Commercial Bank of Ethiopia market share	**49.1 percent of banking assets; 48.1 percent of deposits**[1]	End-June 2025
Microfinance	**59 MFIs with 1,238 branches; total assets ETB 81.7 billion (up 35.9 percent); NPL ratio 3.3 percent**[1]	End-June 2025
Insurance	**19 insurers; gross written premium ETB 41.1 billion (up 43.1 percent); total assets ETB 84.9 billion; penetration 0.3 percent**[1]	FY ending June 2025
Digital payments	**135.9 million mobile money accounts, 540,421 agents, 54.0 million mobile banking accounts; digital payments worth more than ETB 18.5 trillion; 21 licensed non-bank entities (15 payment system operators, 6 payment instrument issuers)**[1]	FY2024/25 (end-June 2025)
Capital market	**7 companies listed on the ESX (Wegagen Bank, Gadaa Bank, Awash Bank, Ethio Telecom, Abay Bank, Bank of Abyssinia, Sidama Bank); 21 licensed capital market service providers including 8 investment banks and 11 securities investment advisors**[5]	Listings January 2025 to September 2026; CMSP count July 2026

Returns and yields

Measure	Value	Period	What it measures
Bank return on equity	**27.4 percent (up from 24.6 percent)**[1]	FY ending June 30, 2025	Banking sector return on equity (RoE)
Bank return on assets	**2.5 percent (up from 2 percent)**[1]	FY ending June 30, 2025	Banking sector return on assets (RoA)
Microfinance return on equity and assets	**RoE 27.5 percent; RoA 5.3 percent**[1]	End-June 2025	MFI sector profitability ratios, the highest in five years
Insurance sector profitability	**Net income before tax ETB 8.3 billion; combined ratio 86.4 percent**[1]	FY ending June 2025	Insurance sector aggregate results
Insurers' investment return	**10.6 percent five-year average, lower than the inflation rate**[1]	Five years to June 2025	Average return on insurers' investments; NBE attributes the low level to the requirement to hold over 50 percent of assets in bank deposits
Commercial bank long-term lending rate	**18 percent (June 2025); 17.9 percent (September 2025)**[1]	June and September 2025	Weighted average long-term lending interest rate
Treasury bill benchmark	**All T-bills weighted average 12.3 percent; 91-day 11.0 percent**[6]	May 2026	Weighted average Treasury bill yields

Profitability ratios are sector aggregates published by the National Bank of Ethiopia for the fiscal year ending June 2025; no permitted source publishes returns for individual new entrants or for ESX-listed equities.

Investment opportunities

- **Foreign entry into banking.** The Banking Business Proclamation lets foreign banks enter through a subsidiary or branch or by buying shares in domestic banks. NBE draft directives cap aggregate foreign ownership of a domestic bank at 49 percent and a strategic investor at 40 percent.[2]
- **New bank licenses.** Under the NBE draft licensing directive, a new domestic bank or foreign bank subsidiary needs minimum paid-up capital of Birr 5 billion, and a foreign bank branch needs Birr 5 billion in branch capital remitted in foreign currency.[4]
- **Capital market services.** ECMA has licensed 21 capital market service providers, and the ESX has listed seven companies since January 2025, including six banks and Ethio Telecom.[5]
- **Underpenetrated insurance.** Insurance penetration is 0.3 percent, yet gross written premium grew 43.1 percent to ETB 41.1 billion in FY2024/25.[1]
- **Digital payments and fintech.** Mobile money reached 135.9 million accounts and digital payments nearly doubled to more than ETB 18.5 trillion, with 21 licensed non-bank payment entities. The proclamation also creates a regulatory sandbox for innovative financial services.[1]

Incentives

- The Banking Business Proclamation provides a regulatory sandbox for new and innovative financial services and brings representatives of foreign banks under NBE regulation.[2]
- Deposit and lending rates are freely set by each bank under Interest Rates Directive No. NBE/INT/13/2026, effective January 9, 2026, with no floors or caps.[7]
- Capital repatriation and remittance of dividends and interest are guaranteed to foreign investors; EIC lists financial services as an emerging sector.[8]

Risks to consider

- Concentration: the state-owned Commercial Bank of Ethiopia holds 49.1 percent of banking assets, and trade accounts for 41.5 percent of loans.[1]
- Financial sector stakeholders rank exchange rate movements and inflation as the most significant short-term risks; operational risk is rising with financial fraud and crime.[1]
- The IMF says foreign bank entry 'will take time', and flags particularly fast private credit growth at the Commercial Bank of Ethiopia, whose asset quality review was due by June 2026.[3]
- The foreign equity and licensing directives we reviewed are NBE drafts with blank numbers and effective dates, so the final rules may differ.[4]

Sources

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